

Potable water for AI, why aren't we doing more?

Posted by u/Big-Grocery7772 • 0 points • 0 comments

****While most of us has now learned why AI uses water. I thought about how truly sad it is that even AI has more accessible and on hands potable water, than humans do. Actually. Like they all have clean water all the time. According to the "world health organization" 1 in 4 – or 2.1 billion people globally – still lack access to safely managed drinking water*, including 106 million who drink directly from untreated surface sources."**

They could just use dirty water and filter it themselves right? Money is by far an issue so?? So I researched a bit to understand. Bc wtf, genuinely. Turns out the simple reason is comfortability. Because they can. It's easier, faster, there's no concrete laws that can even make them consider doing it. I want to hear your thoughts on this. Why aren't we doing more?*

Comments

u/notaredditer13 • 1 points • 2026-04-02 01:15 UTC

?? Data centers in Virginia are not taking potable water from Ethiopia. And even at that, this is a vastly overblown issue: almost all industrial cooling in the USA is evaporative and the amount of water needed sounds big* but really isn't. It depends on the size of course but they are on the same order of magnitude as a golf course. And comparisons to residential water consumption are fallacious because residences simply don't use the water for the same thing (our air conditioning) and that causes houses to use MORE energy per unit of cooling (evaporative cooling is more efficient).

*The "all big numbers are big" fallacy.

u/Namika • 1 points • 2026-04-01 22:47 UTC

North America doesn't have a water shortage.

People dying of thirst in South Africa are not affected by water usage taking place 4000 miles across the ocean.

u/codefyre • 4 points • 2026-04-01 22:46 UTC

Keep in mind that, with only small exceptions, water tends to be a local resource. The water usage policies of Ireland, or Romania, or Ohio have no real impact on the availability of potable water in places like Sub-Saharan Africa or southern Asia, where the majority of people who lack access to clean drinking water are located. So the global statistics are interesting, but not particularly relevant.

Locally, datacenter water usage is also an issue of varying importance. Some areas have plenty of water, so datacenter water usage doesn't have much impact. Other areas are so arid that datacenters consume water that is needed for people, agriculture, and the environment. In those places, people should be pushing their legislators HARD to regulate them and keep them away from potable water sources. At a minimum, they should be using greywater. The problem is that its a *local* issue, which makes it difficult to organize a larger opposition to make that happen. Voters in Wyoming don't typically care much if a datacenter operator wants to open a new location in Nevada, because it has no impact on Wyoming.

u/MoistCloyster_ • 3 points • 2026-04-01 22:42 UTC

Well most of those 2.1 billion are in countries where data centers aren't being built. AI use is controversial but it does have its benefits to humanity so it makes sense in this regard at least.

While in an ideal world, those countries without the means of solving its water issues would get help from other countries, the reality is that other countries are more preoccupied with their own problems to do anything more than send some occasional funding.

u/NoSoulsINC • 2 points • 2026-04-01 22:41 UTC

What's your proposed solution?

u/fly_awayyy • 1 points • 2026-04-01 22:38 UTC

In Northern Virginia basically the data center ally of the world...most of the data centers use just that it's recycled water they have a separate feed from the utility. Although they say it's the same standard as normal water...the fact they attempt to do that is something.

u/BigRichard1990 • 1 points • 2026-04-01 22:53 UTC

Also, Northern Virginia has plenty of water, with two large rivers flowing into the Chesapeake estuary without even an attempt to dam it up for use in a reservoir. The minor Occoquan river reservoir provides plenty of water, and also, one of America's top rowing destinations. The upper Potomac has a few short dams. The water used for cooling is just evaporated, it isn't polluted or contaminated with anything but joules.

u/fly_awayyy • 1 points • 2026-04-01 23:12 UTC

Well it's been an evolving situation the past 2-3yrs. The build up of most data centers is in Loudoun County which gets its water from the Potomac. We've been getting into climate patterns that have put us in a drought the past 2-3yrs and even right now so locally this has been a increasing talking point about water shortages if these climate pretends continues atleast for Loudoun county.

u/BigRichard1990 • 1 points • 2026-04-02 00:04 UTC

I have been downstream of all those places and there has never been a peep about a lack of water. Don't let scientists scare you — people live in Las Vegas and if anything happened to Hoover Dam, they would have to evacuate. There will be enough water for everyone to drink. We have a long way to go before we have to cut back on drinking water. Lol. Renewable resources should be used to create prosperity. Non-renewable ones too.